

French, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

Companion practice lessons live alongside this book at
`code/learning/human-languages/french/lessons/`

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Preface

This is the French volume of a wider project, and it is written for someone starting from zero, whose only shared language is English. French is taught one word at a time, and each word is taken apart — traced to its root (usually Latin), then forward to the English cousins you already own, so nothing is a fresh thing to memorize. *jour* ("day") arrives next to *journal* and *journey*; *salut* ("hi") turns out to wish you *health*, like *salute* and *salubrious*.

French has a close sibling in Spanish — both are worn-down Latin — so where a French word and its Spanish cousin descend from one Latin root, the book shows both and dwells on the *difference* between them (why the same *dies* became French *jour* but Spanish *día*; why French keeps *bonjour* singular where Spanish pluralizes *buenos días*). Every such comparison is supplied in full by the text — no prior Spanish is assumed; it is offered as enrichment, and a reader who happens to know Spanish simply nods along.

Three things shape every lesson: one word per lesson, gone deep; the widest *honest* web of cousins; and the cultural or idiomatic reason a thing is said, not just the rule. Pronunciation is a short reference at the front, never a gate. Released under CC BY-SA 4.0.

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Pronunciation — a reference, not a chapter

Not to be read before starting. Each lesson names the sounds its word needs and points here for more. French spelling hides more sound than Spanish — silent letters, nasal vowels, liaison — so this page is worth dipping into, but it is never a wall to climb first.

Three habits to unlearn

- **Silent final consonants.** Most are silent: *salut* = *sa-LU* (no *t*); *les* = *lay* (no *s*). Usually kept: final *c*, *r*, *f*, *l*.
- **Nasal vowels.** *on*, *an*, *in* send the vowel through the nose and silence the *n*: *bon* = *bõ*, *bien* = *byẽ*.
- **Liaison.** A silent final consonant can reconnect onto a following vowel (*vous avez* = *vou-zavez*). Later.

Vowels

- **ou** = *oo* (*jour* = *zhoor*).
- **u** = a front-rounded *ee* with pursed lips (*salut*, *tu*) — no English equivalent, not *oo*.
- **oi** = *wa* (*soir* = *swahr*).
- **é** = crisp *ay*; **è/ê** = open *eh*.

Nasal vowels

- **on/om** = nasal *õ* (*bon, bonjour*).
- **in/ain/ien** = nasal *ẽ* (*bien, bientôt*).
- **an/en** = nasal *ã* (*comment, enchanté*).
- A doubled *nn/mm* cancels the nasal: *bon* (*bõ*) vs. *bonne* (*bun*).

Consonants that differ

- **j** (and soft **g**) = the *zh* of *measure* (*jour*).
- **r** = a soft guttural at the back of the throat — not the Spanish tap nor the English *r*.
- **h** = always silent. **ch** = English *sh* (*enchanté*). **gn** = *ny* (= Spanish *ñ*).

Accents

French accents mark *vowel quality*, not stress (unlike Spanish): *é* (closed), *è/ê* (open), *ç* (soft *s*). French stresses the last syllable of a group, lightly and evenly.

Chapter 1

Greetings

The French greetings, built from their pieces — a word for “good,” words for “day,” “evening,” “night,” and the gender machine that decides their endings. French and Spanish are both daughters of Latin; where a French word and its Spanish cousin split from one Latin root, both appear here, because the *difference* between them is often the lesson — and the text supplies the Spanish word whether or not you have met it before. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C01-*.md.*

1.1 *salut* — “hi,” a wish for your health

Sounds you’ll need

Final **t** is silent: *salut* = *sa-LU*. The **u** is the front-rounded French *u*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

salut (informal “hi/bye”) ← Latin *salus*, *salutem* (“health, safety”). So *salut* literally wishes *health* — like old English “hail.” Cousins: **salute**, **salutation**, **salutary**, **salubrious**; and via *salvus* (“safe”), *save*, *salvation*.

Why it’s said this way

Strictly **informal**, and doubles as “bye.” For respect or a first meeting you reach for *bonjour* — just as Spanish, the other Latin daughter, reaches past its own casual *hola* for the fuller *buenos días*.

1.2 *bien* — “well”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bien (“well”) ← Latin *bene* → **benefit**, **benevolent**, **benediction**. Spanish, from the same *bene*, kept the very same spelling, *bien* — the two Romance languages inherited the adverb almost unchanged.

A complete one-word answer: *Comment ça va?* → *Bien.*; intensified, *très bien*. The adverb (“well”); the *adjective* “good” is a different word, *bon*, next.

1.3 *bon* / *bonne* — “good”

Sounds you’ll need

bon is nasal *bõ* (silent *n*); but **bonne** (feminine) is *bun* — the doubled *nn* cancels the nasal, so the two *sound* different despite looking alike.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bon / **bonne** ← Latin *bonus* / *bona* → **bonus**, **bonanza**, **bounty** (via *bonté*), *bonbon*. Spanish, from the same *bonus* / *bona*, made *bueno* / *buena* — where French kept the *o* short, Spanish broke it into a diphthong (*o* → *ue*).

Grammar Lens

bon **agrees** with its noun in gender and number — *bon* (m.), *bonne* (f.), *bons* (m.pl.), *bonnes* (f.pl.). This gender-agreement of adjectives is Latin’s legacy across the Romance languages (Spanish runs the same machine on *bueno* / *buena*). You’ll watch it: *bon jour* (m.) but *bonne nuit* (f.).

1.4 *le / la / les* — “the,” and the gender it carries

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

le ← *ille*, **la** ← *illa*, **les** ← *illos* — Latin demonstratives (“that one/those”) worn down into “the.” Spanish, from the very same *ille* / *illa* / *illos*, has *el* / *la* / *los*; and those same Latin demonstratives also gave French **il** / **elle** (“he/she”). (English “the” is Germanic — unrelated.)

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Every French noun is masculine or feminine — Latin’s three genders (masculine, feminine, neuter) collapsed to two, the neuter folding mostly into the masculine. Learn each noun *with* its article. French has one convenience: in the plural, both genders share a single article, *les*.

1.5 *jour* — “day,” and the road to English *journey*

Sounds you’ll need

j = *zh* (as in *measure*); **ou** = *oo*. So *jour* = *zhoor*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

le jour (masc.) ← Latin *diurnum* (“daytime”), from *dies* (“day”). That detour through *diurnum* is why *jour* looks nothing like Spanish *día* (which took *dies* directly). Cousins, mostly via French: **journal**, **journey** (a *day’s* travel — *journée*), **sojourn**, **adjourn** (*à jour*); and via *dies*: **diurnal**, **diary**.

So English journey and Spanish día are cousins, meeting at Latin dies — one through French, one direct.

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jour is **masculine** (*le jour*). Plural adds a silent *-s* (*les jours*) — heard only in *les*.

1.6 *bonjour* — assembled, and *not* plural

bon (“good”) + *jour* (“day”) = “good day,” one word, *bõ-zhoor*; *bon* is masculine because *jour* is.

Why it’s said this way

The contrast to bank: Spanish says *buenos días* — **plural**, the fossil of a blessing. French says *bonjour* — **singular**, just “good day.” Same two blocks, same roots; Spanish pluralized the blessing, French didn’t. And culturally *bonjour* is near-obligatory — opening a shop or a conversation *without* one reads as rude.

1.7 *soir* — “evening,” the same “late” Spanish used

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

le soir (masc., *swahr*) ← Latin *sērum* (“the **late** hour”), from *sērus* (“late”). Cousin: *soirée*. Spanish, from the same instinct, named its “afternoon” *tarde* ← *tardus*, “**late**” — two languages, two “late” words, the same idea of naming the later day after its lateness.

Grammar Lens

le soir is **masculine**; plural *les soirs* (the *-s* silent, heard only in *les*).

1.8 *bonsoir* — good evening

bon + *soir* (masc.) = “good evening,” *bõ-swahr*; *bon* stays masculine. The evening swap for *bonjour*, and — like Spanish *buenas noches* — usable both arriving and leaving.

1.9 *nuit* — “night,” and a sound-change mirroring Spanish

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la nuit (fem., *nwee*) ← Latin *noctem* (*noct-*) → **nocturnal**, **equinox**.
The change is a *rule*, side by side with Spanish: Latin *-ct-* → Spanish *-ch-*, French *-it-*.

Latin	Spanish	French	English
<i>noctem</i>	noche	nuit	night
<i>lactem</i>	leche	lait	(lact-)
<i>factum</i>	hecho	fait	fact

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nuit is **feminine** (*la nuit*, from feminine Latin *nox*) — which is why “good night” is *bonne nuit*. Plural *les nuits*.

1.10 *bonne nuit* — good night, and the feminine *bon*

bonne (fem.) + *nuit* (fem.) = “good night” (*bun nwee*). At last *bon* in its feminine coat — and the whole agreement rule in one view:

bonjour (*jour* m. → *bon*) *bonsoir* (*soir* m. → *bon*) *bonne nuit* (*nuit* f. → *bonne*)

Why it’s said this way

Unlike *bonsoir* (an evening greeting), *bonne nuit* is a **farewell for bed**. French keeps them separate where Spanish overloads *buenas noches* for both. Next chapter: introducing yourself, and French’s own *tu* vs. *vous*.

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

— *Je m’appelle Mira.*
— *Comment vous appelez-vous?*
— *Je m’appelle Arun.*
— *Enchanté.*

We build it the same way as the greetings: each piece taken apart first, then assembled. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C02-*.md.*

2.1 *je* — “I,” the smallest word you own

Sounds you’ll need

zhuh — soft *j* (as in *measure*), a light *uh*. Before a vowel it elides to *j’*:
je ai → *j’ai*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

je (“I”) ← Latin *ego*. The Latin form survives raw in English **ego**, **egoist**, **egotism** — so the word for “I” and the psychologist’s “ego” are the *same* ancient word, one worn down to a whisper (*je*), one kept whole. (Spanish took *ego* to *yo*; French wore it further, to *je*.)

2.2 *me* — “myself,” the same word as English *me*

Sounds you’ll need

muh — a light *uh*, like *je*. Before a vowel it elides to *m’*: *me appelle* → *m’appelle*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

me (“me, myself”) ← Latin *mē* (the accusative “me”) — literally the *same* word as English **me**. The whole family grows from one Proto-Indo-European root **me-*: English **me**, **my**, **mine**; Latin *mē* and *meus* (“my,” which became French *mon* / *ma* / *mes*). So the little *m’* in *je m’appelle* is a first-person marker you have owned in English all your life.

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The reflexive set. *me* is one of three pronouns that bounce a verb back on its doer: *me* (myself), *te* (yourself), *se* (himself/herself). Their roots run in parallel: *te* ← Latin *tē* (cousin of archaic English **thee**), *se* ← Latin *sē* (the “self” root behind **separate** and, distantly, **suicide**, *suī* “of oneself”). You’ll use *me* to say your name and *te* in the informal “what’s your name?”

2.3 *(s’)appeler* — “to call,” and “to call *oneself*”

Sounds you’ll need

a-play; the *-er* ending of the infinitive is a plain “ay.” In *m’appelle* the doubled *ll* keeps a crisp “l.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

appeler (“to call”) ← Latin *appellāre* (“to address, call by name”). A rich English family: **appeal** (call to a higher authority), **appellation** (a name), **appellate** (a court that hears appeals), **appellant**. To name someone is, at root, to *call* them.

2.4. JE M'APPELLE... — “MY NAME IS...,” LITERALLY “I CALL MYSELF”¹¹

Grammar Lens

Reflexive verbs — doing something to yourself. Pair this verb with the *me* you just met (§2.2) and you get *s'appeler*, “to call *oneself*”: *je me appelle*, “I call myself.” That is how French says a name — not “my name is” but “I call myself.” (English has the same move, hidden in “I call *myself*.”)

2.4 *je m'appelle...* — “my name is...,” literally “I call myself”

je (I, §2.1) + *me* (myself, §2.2, elided to *m'* before the vowel) + *appelle* (call, §2.3) = **je m'appelle...** — word for word “I call myself...,” and the everyday way to say “**my name is...**” *Je m'appelle Arun.* = “My name is Arun.” Three atoms, each traced; now they click together.

Why it's said this way

French *prefers* this verb-based “I call myself” to a literal “my name is.” The literal version, *mon nom est...* (“my name is...,” with *nom* ← Latin *nōmen* → English **noun**, **nominate**, **nominal**), exists and is understood, but it sounds stiff or officious — a form for a passport desk, not a introduction. Reach for *je m'appelle*.

2.5 *tu / vous* — “you,” familiar and formal

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tu (familiar “you”) ← Latin *tū*; **vous** (formal/plural “you”) ← Latin *vōs* (“you all”). English lost the distinction — old *thou* was the *tu*, now vanished, leaving one flat *you* for everyone.

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Two “you”s, chosen by register. *tu* is for friends, family, children, peers; *vous* is for strangers, elders, anyone you’d show respect — and it doubles as the plural “you all.” French makes politeness by using the *plural* on one person (the verb has its own name for this: *vouvoyer*). This is the same politeness Spanish builds with *usted*, but by a differ-

ent mechanism: Spanish invented a new pronoun (from “your grace”); French just uses “you all” for one respected person. Using *tu* too soon can read as over-familiar — when unsure, *vous*.

2.6 *comment* — “how,” the same *quomodo* behind Spanish *cómo*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

comment (“how”) ← Latin *quo modo* (“in what manner”), the two words fused and worn down. That exact phrase *quomodo* also became Spanish *cómo* — two Romance languages, one Latin “in-what-way,” reshaped differently. The piece *modo* (“manner, measure”) is itself alive in English **mode**, **model**, **moderate**.

Grammar Lens

French uses *comment* (“how”) where English uses “what” for names — literally “*how* are you called?”, not “*what* is your name?”. The question is about the *manner* of your calling. Keep the French logic: *comment* = “how,” and the name-question is built on it.

2.7 *comment vous appelez-vous?* — “what’s your name?”

comment (how) + *vous appelez-vous* (“do you call yourself,” with the verb and *vous* swapped for a question) = literally “**how do you call yourself?**” — the polite “what’s your name?”

Grammar Lens

Asking by inversion. A statement, *vous vous appelez* (“you call yourself”), becomes a question by flipping verb and pronoun: *vous appelez-vous?* (with a hyphen). The informal version simply swaps in *tu*: *comment tu t’appelles?* — note *te* elides to *t’*, exactly as *me* became *m’*.

2.8 *enchanté* — “delighted,” i.e. “pleased to meet you”

Sounds you’ll need

ahn-shahn-TAY: two nasal vowels (*en*, *an*), then a clean “tay.” *ch* = English *sh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

enchanté (“delighted”) ← Latin *in-* (“upon”) + *cantāre* (“to sing, chant”): to *enchant* was literally to *sing a spell upon* someone. English kept the magic in **enchant**, **incantation**, and the plain **chant**. To say *enchanté* on meeting someone is to say, gallantly, “I’m *enchanted*.”

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It agrees with *you*. *enchanté* follows the gender rule from §1.4: a man says *enchanté*, a woman *enchantee* (an extra *-e*, same sound). The adjective reports the speaker’s own gender.

2.9 The whole exchange

French	English
<i>Je m’appelle Mira.</i>	My name is Mira.
<i>Comment vous appelez-vous?</i>	What’s your name?
<i>Je m’appelle Arun.</i>	My name is Arun.
<i>Enchanté.</i>	Pleased to meet you.

Every piece was built from a root: *je* from *ego*, *appeler* from *appellāre* (appeal/appellation), *comment* from *quo modo*, *enchanté* from *in-cantāre*. Next chapter: *Comment ça va?* (“how’s it going?”) and answering with *bien* again — the recursive responding cycle.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

Now the small talk that follows a name — thanking, answering a thank-you, and asking how someone is doing. French asks that last question with a verb of *motion*: not “how are you?” but “how does it *go*?”

- *Comment allez-vous?*
- *Très bien, merci. Et vous?*
- *Comme ci, comme ça.*

Each piece is taken apart first, then assembled. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C03-*.md.*

3.1 *merci* — “thank you,” and it means *mercy*

Sounds you’ll need

mehr-SEE, with the soft guttural French *r* made at the back of the throat (never a tapped or rolled *r*). The stress falls at the end: *mehr-SEE*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

merci (“thank you”) ← Latin *mercēs* (“wages, reward, price, that which is earned”). Saying *merci* originally invoked a **reward** owed for a kindness — and, in old religious use, a plea for divine **mercy**, a reward you have not earned.

That one root *merc-* (“pay, trade, reward”) pays out a large English family: **mercy**, **merciful** (the reward/pity sense); **mercenary** (a soldier who fights for *wages*); and, through Latin *mercārī* (“to trade”), **merchant**, **commerce**, **market**, **mercantile**. Even **Mercury**, the Roman god of merchants, is family.

Why it's said this way

Three sisters, three pictures of gratitude. The Romance languages each chose a different metaphor for “thank you.” French *merci* comes from *mercēs*, a **reward** (and so, mercy). Spanish *gracias* comes from Latin *grātia*, **grace** or favour. Portuguese *obrigado* comes from Latin *obligātus*, “I am **obliged**.” Same feeling, three quite different pictures — French hands you a reward, Spanish hands you grace, Portuguese declares itself in your debt.

3.2 *de rien* — “you’re welcome,” literally “of nothing”

Sounds you’ll need

duh ryan, where that final syllable is **nasal**: the air goes out through the nose and there is no hard *n* at the end. Two things to keep: the nasal ending of *rien*, and the guttural French *r* at the back of the throat.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

de (“of, from”) ← Latin *dē*. **rien** (“nothing”) ← Latin *rem*, the accusative of *rēs*, “a thing.”

In Latin *rem* meant a **thing**, something real. French kept using it inside negations — *ne ...rien*, “not ...a thing” — until the word for *thing* absorbed the negation around it and **rien came to mean “nothing” all by itself**. Latin *rēs* also gives English **real**, **republic** (*rēs pūblica*, “the public thing”), and **rebus**. So *rien* is, at the root, a *real thing* that learned to mean nothing at all.

Why it's said this way

The same move, twice. Spanish did the identical thing with *nada*, which comes from Latin *nāta*, “a born thing” — again a *thing* word that collapsed into a *nothing* word. The two replies sit side by side:

Language	“You’re welcome”	The “nothing” word
French	<i>de rien</i>	<i>rien</i> ← <i>rem</i> , “a thing”
Spanish	<i>de nada</i>	<i>nada</i> ← <i>nāta</i> , “a born thing”

3.3. ALLER — “TO GO,” THE VERB BEHIND “HOW ARE YOU?”¹⁷

Two sister languages, one instinct: wave the favour off as no *thing* at all.

3.3 *aller* — “to go,” the verb behind “how are you?”

Sounds you’ll need

The infinitive ending *-er* is a clean “ay”: *aller* = *ah-LAY*. The doubled *ll* is just one *l* sound, and the *r* of the ending is silent.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

aller (“to go”) is one of the great messes of French: it is **suppletive**, meaning it was stitched together out of **three** different Latin verbs, and the seams still show in its everyday forms.

je vais (“I go”) ← Latin *vādere*, “to go, to rush” → English **invade**, **evade**, **wade** — all going-words.

nous allons (“we go”), and the infinitive *aller* itself, ← Latin *ambulāre*, “to walk” → English **amble**, **ambulance** (a walking hospital), **preamble**, **perambulate**.

j’irai (“I will go”) ← Latin *īre*, “to go” → English **exit** (*ex-it*, “he goes out”), **transit**, **initial**.

So one French verb carries three separate Latin roots for motion.

Grammar Lens

“**Going**” used for “**being**.” You do not need to conjugate *aller* yet — only to recognize one form: *ça va*, “it goes” (the *va* is the *vādere* piece). Many languages borrow a verb of motion to talk about a *state*: English asks “how are you getting on?” or “how’s it going?” French made exactly that the standard question. Spanish instead asks with *estar*, “to stand” (*¿cómo estás?*). One language stands, the other walks — two different pictures of a life.

3.4 *comment ça va?* — “how are you?”

comment (how, §2.6) + *ça* (it, this) + *va* (goes, from *aller*, §3.3) = **Comment ça va?** — word for word, “How does *it* go?” and the single most

useful question in spoken French.

ça means “it, this,” worn down from Latin *ecce hoc*, “behold this.” The two-word version, *Ça va?* (“It goes?”), is what people actually say — and you can answer it with the very same two words: *Ça va*. (“It goes” = “I’m fine.”)

Grammar Lens

A ladder of three registers. French offers a neat climb from casual to formal. *tu* is the familiar “you” (a friend, a peer); *vous* is the formal or plural “you” (a stranger, an elder, a group).

Register	Question	Literally
Casual, universal	<i>Comment ça va?</i> (or <i>Ça va?</i>)	“How does <i>it</i> go?”
Informal, one friend	<i>Comment vas-tu?</i>	“How go <i>you</i> ?”
Formal or plural	<i>Comment allez-vous?</i>	“How go <i>you</i> (<i>vous</i>)?”

vas and *allez* are simply the *tu* and *vous* forms of *aller*. For a stranger or a boss, reach for *Comment allez-vous?*

Sounds you’ll need

comment ends in a nasal vowel and a silent *t*: *ko-mahn*. But in *Comment allez-vous* that silent *t* wakes up and glues onto the following vowel — this is called **liaison** — *ko-mahn-ta-lay-VOO*.

3.5 *comme ci, comme ça* — the classic French shrug

Someone asks *Ça va?* and you are neither great nor bad. The perfect answer — a phrase English borrowed whole — is **comme ci, comme ça**, literally “like this, like that.” A verbal shrug of the shoulders.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

comme (“like, as”) ← Latin *quōmodo*, “in what manner” — the *same* root as *comment* (“how”, §2.6). One Latin word, two French children: *comment* is “in what manner?” asked as a question, *comme* is “in the manner of, like.”

ci (“here, this”) ← Latin *ecce hic*, “behold here.” **ça** (“there, that”) ← Latin *ecce hoc*, “behold this” — the very same *ça* as in *Ça va?*

So you are literally waving a hand: *a bit like this way, a bit like that way* — neither up nor down.

Grammar Lens

Your answer set for *Ça va?* Recall *bien*, “well” (§1.2, from Latin *bene*); *Ça va bien* is “it’s going well.”

Answer	Sense
<i>(Très) bien, merci</i>	(Very) well, thank you
<i>Ça va</i>	Fine, okay (“it goes”)
<i>Comme ci, comme ça</i>	So-so
<i>Pas mal</i>	Not bad

Why it’s said this way

Every language has its shrug, and each paints it differently: Spanish says *más o menos* (“more or less”) or *regular*; Italian says *così così* (“so so”); French says *comme ci, comme ça* (“like this, like that”). Same gesture, three pictures.

3.6 The whole exchange

No new words — this chapter’s atoms assemble into a real exchange, run once formally and once informally. The glue is *et vous?* / *et toi?*, “and you?” (*et* = “and,” from Latin *et*; *toi* is the stressed form of *tu*). It bounces the question straight back, exactly as Spanish does with *¿y usted?* / *¿y tú?*

Formal — a stranger, an elder:

— *Bonjour. Comment allez-vous?*
 — *Très bien, merci. Et vous?*
 — *Comme ci, comme ça.*
 — [after a small favour] *Merci!* — *De rien.*

Informal — a friend:

— *Salut! Ça va?*
 — *Ça va, et toi?*
 — *Comme ci, comme ça.*

French	English
<i>Merci.</i>	Thank you.
<i>De rien.</i>	You're welcome.
<i>Comment allez-vous?</i>	How are you? (formal)
<i>Comment vas-tu?</i>	How are you? (informal)
<i>Ça va?</i>	How's it going?
<i>Ça va bien.</i>	It's going well.
<i>Comme ci, comme ça.</i>	So-so.
<i>Pas mal.</i>	Not bad.

Every piece came from a root: *merci* from *mercēs* (“reward, mercy”), *rien* from *rem* (“a thing”), *aller* from *ambulāre*, *vādere* and *īre*, *comme* from *quōmodo*. Next chapter: the farewells — *au revoir*, *à bientôt*, *à demain*.

Chapter 4

Farewells

You can open a French conversation; now close it. French has one plain goodbye and a small family of soft ones, all built the same way — the preposition *à* (“to”) followed by a time word:

— *Bon...à demain, Marc.*
— *À demain, Chloé. Au revoir!*

Practice lessons: *lessons/FR-CO4-*.md*.

4.1 *au revoir* — “goodbye,” i.e. “until we see each other again”

Sounds you’ll need

oh ruh-VWAHR, with two guttural French *r*’s made at the back of the throat. The letter pair *oi* is pronounced *wa*, so *-voir* = *vwahr* (the same *oi* as in *soir*, §1.7).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

au revoir is *au* + *revoir*, “at the re-seeing.” *au* is a fusion of *à* (“to, at”) + *le* (“the”). *revoir* is **re-** (“again”) + **voir** (“to see”), so the whole phrase literally means “**until the seeing-again**” — a small promise that this is not the end.

voir comes from Latin *vidēre*, “to see,” one of the richest roots English owns: **vision**, **visible**, **visit**, **visa**, **view**, **video** (“I see”); and with prefixes, **revise** (“look again”), **evident** (“seen out”), **provide**, **supervise**, **survey**.

Why it's said this way

A goodbye that sees. German builds its farewell out of exactly the same idea: *Auf Wiedersehen* is *auf* (“on”) + *wieder* (“again”) + *sehen* (“to see”) — “on the seeing-again.” French and German, side by side, both promise a re-seeing. Spanish *adiós* takes a different road entirely: it commends you *to God* (*a Dios*). Same moment of parting, two quite different pictures.

4.2 à plus tard — the casual “see you later”**Sounds you'll need**

In the full phrase, *plus* is *ploo* with a silent *s*, and *tard* is *tar* with a silent *d*: *ah ploo TAR*. But in the clipped form *à plus*, the *s* is sounded: *ah PLUSS*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

à (“to, at”) ← Latin *ad* — French’s all-purpose farewell preposition.
plus (“more”) ← Latin *plūs*, the very **plus** you already write in English, and the *plu-* of **plural** and **surplus**. **tard** (“late”) ← Latin *tarde*, “slowly, late” → English **tardy** and **retard** (“to hold back, make late”).

So *à plus tard* is literally “to more late” — see you at some later point. Among friends it shrinks to just *à plus*.

Why it's said this way

Spanish inherited that identical Latin *tarde* — but the two languages grew it in different directions. French kept it meaning **late** (*tard*); Spanish grew it into **afternoon** (*tarde*). One Latin word, two everyday meanings. And where French leans on *à* for its soft goodbyes, Spanish leans on *hasta* (“until”): *hasta luego* is the twin of *à plus tard*.

4.3 à *bientôt* — “see you soon”

Sounds you’ll need

bien is nasal — *byan*, air through the nose, no hard *n*. *bientôt* = *byan-TOH*; the circumflex on *ô* simply marks a long *o*, and the final *t* is silent. The whole phrase: *ah byan-TOH*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

à **bientôt** = “to soon” → “see you soon.” The second word is a compound you can pull apart: **bien** (“well,” §1.2, from Latin *bene* — the *bene* of **benefit**) + **tôt** (“early, soon”) = “well-soon,” that is, *quite soon*. The circumflex on *ô* is itself a history lesson: in French a circumflex usually marks an **s that dropped out**. *hôtel* was once *hostel*; *forêt* was once *forest*; and *tôt* came from an older *tost*. The little hat is the ghost of a lost *s*.

Grammar Lens

bien, the intensifier. You met *bien* as “well,” an answer to *Ça va?* Here it does a second job: it glues onto another word to strengthen it. *bien* + *tôt* = *bientôt*, “soon indeed.” French loves this move — *bienvenue* (“welcome”) is literally *bien* + *venue*, “well-come.” Same word, new trick.

4.4 à *demain* — “see you tomorrow”

Sounds you’ll need

demain = *duh-MAN*, where the ending *-ain* is a nasal vowel (the same nasal as in *pain*, *main*) and the final consonant is silent. The whole phrase: *ah duh-MAN*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

à **demain** = “to tomorrow” → “see you tomorrow.” **demain** (“tomorrow”) ← Latin *dē māne*, “from the morning”: *dē* = “from,” *māne* = “in the morning.” The next morning is *tomorrow*, and the two words fused into *demain*.

English keeps that *māne* too, in the poetic **matins** (morning prayers) and in **matinée**, a daytime show.

Why it's said this way

The hidden twin. Spanish *mañana* (“tomorrow, morning”) comes from Latin (*hōra*) *maneana*, built on the *same māne* (“morning”). So French *demain* and Spanish *mañana* are cousins through one Latin word — both turning “morning” into “tomorrow,” just assembled differently: French says *from-morning*, Spanish says *morning-ish hour*.

Grammar Lens

The à ... farewells, complete. All of French’s soft goodbyes are *à* + a time word, where Spanish uses *hasta* (“until”) + a time word:

French	Spanish	When
<i>à plus tard</i> (or <i>à plus</i>)	<i>hasta luego</i>	Later — the default
<i>à bientôt</i>	<i>hasta pronto</i>	Soon
<i>à demain</i>	<i>hasta mañana</i>	Tomorrow

And *au revoir* for the plain goodbye.

4.5 Saying goodbye, start to finish

No new words. The farewells now close a real conversation and fold back into everything since *salut*.

You are...	Say
Parting plainly or politely	<i>Au revoir.</i>
Expecting to meet again shortly	<i>À bientôt.</i>
Casually saying “see you”	<i>À plus (tard).</i>
Leaving for the day	<i>À demain.</i>

The whole exchange, drawing on Chapters 1 through 4:

— *Salut! Je m'appelle Chloé. Comment tu t'appelles?*
 — *Je m'appelle Marc. Enchanté.*
 — *Ça va?*

- *Ça va bien, merci, et toi?*
- *Très bien. Bon...à demain, Marc.*
- *À demain, Chloé. Au revoir!*

What this chapter built: *au revoir*, the plain goodbye that promises a *re-seeing* (the *vidēre* family, twin of German *Auf Wiedersehen*); and *à plus tard* / *à bientôt* / *à demain* — later, soon, tomorrow, all *à* + a time, mirroring Spanish's *hasta*. You can now hold a whole short French exchange, hello to goodbye. Next chapter: your first verbs, and your first sentence built from scratch.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Until now you have assembled fixed phrases. This chapter hands you a *pattern* instead: the regular *-er* verbs, the largest verb family in French by a wide margin. Learn the one template and thousands of verbs come with it — and with it you build your first sentence that nobody handed you pre-made. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C05-*.md.*

5.1 *parler* — “to speak,” the model *-er* verb

Sounds you’ll need

The infinitive ending *-er* is a clean “ay”: *parler* = *par-LAY* (the *r* of that ending is silent). What is left when you strip the ending is the **stem**, *parl-*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

parler (“to speak, to talk”) ← Late Latin *parabolāre*, “to tell parables, to discourse,” from *parabola* (“a comparison, a speech”), itself from Greek *parabolē*, “a throwing-beside.” So to *speak*, in French, is at root to *tell parables*.

That root fans out into English: **parable**, the story-comparison itself; **parole**, a spoken word of honour (as a prisoner’s parole); **palaver**, a long talk; **parley**, to talk terms; and even **parliament**, a talking-place.

Grammar Lens

The *-er* present tense. Drop *-er* from the infinitive, then add the ending that belongs to the person. (*je* = I, *tu* = you familiar, *il* / *elle*

= he / she, *nous* = we, *vous* = you formal or plural, *ils* / *elles* = they.)

Person	Ending	<i>parler</i>	Sounds like
<i>je</i>	-e	<i>je parle</i>	<i>parl</i>
<i>tu</i>	-es	<i>tu parles</i>	<i>parl</i>
<i>il</i> / <i>elle</i>	-e	<i>il parle</i>	<i>parl</i>
<i>nous</i>	-ons	<i>nous parlons</i>	<i>par-LON</i>
<i>vous</i>	-ez	<i>vous parlez</i>	<i>par-LAY</i>
<i>ils</i> / <i>elles</i>	-ent	<i>ils parlent</i>	<i>parl</i>

Here is the great French surprise: **-e, -es and -ent are all silent.** *je parle*, *tu parles* and *ils parlent* sound identical — just *parl*. Only the *nous* form (-ons) and the *vous* form (-ez) are audible.

Grammar Lens

Why French keeps its pronouns. That silence has a consequence which shapes the whole language. In Spanish, the ending alone tells you who is speaking — *hablo* (“I speak”) against *hablas* (“you speak”) — so the pronoun can be dropped. In French your ear cannot hear any difference between *parle*, *parles* and *parlent*, so the **pronoun must stay** to carry the person. *Je* and *tu* are not optional decoration in French; they are the only thing telling you who is doing the speaking.

5.2 *habiter* — “to live,” and it is about *having a place*

Sounds you’ll need

The **h** is silent — French *h* is never pronounced. So *habiter* = *a-bee-TAY*, with the same -er = “ay” ending as *parler*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

habiter (“to live, to dwell”) ← Latin *habitāre*, “to dwell, to keep on having [a place]” — the **frequentative** of *habēre*, “to have.” A frequentative is a verb of repeated action, so to *dwell* somewhere is, at root, to *keep having* it as your place.

5.3. TRAVAILLER — “TO WORK,” AND THE TORTURE BEHIND TRAVEL 29

The root is thoroughly at home in English: **habitat**, the place a creature dwells; **inhabit**, **inhabitant**, **habitation**. And through *habēre* (“to have”) come **habit**, what you keep having, and **able** / **ability**, what you have it in you to do.

Grammar Lens

The same template, silent trap and all. Drop *-er*, add the endings — identical to *parler*:

Person	<i>habiter</i>	Sounds like
<i>je</i>	<i>j’habite</i>	<i>a-BEET</i>
<i>tu</i>	<i>tu habites</i>	<i>a-BEET</i>
<i>il / elle</i>	<i>il habite</i>	<i>a-BEET</i>
<i>nous</i>	<i>nous habitons</i>	<i>a-bee-TON</i>
<i>vous</i>	<i>vous habitez</i>	<i>a-bee-TAY</i>
<i>ils / elles</i>	<i>ils habitent</i>	<i>a-BEET</i>

Note *j’habite*: *je* elides to *j’* before the vowel of *habite*. Because the *h* is silent, the word *counts* as beginning with a vowel. With this verb you can answer an *où* (“where”) question: *J’habite à Paris.* — “I live in Paris.”

5.3 *travailler* — “to work,” and the torture behind *travel*

Sounds you’ll need

The letters *-ill-* carry a *y* glide: *travailler* = *tra-va-YAY*, with the same *-er* = “ay” ending. The conjugated *je travaille* is *tra-VYE*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

travailler (“to work”) ← Vulgar Latin *tripaliāre*, “to torture,” from *tripalium*, a Roman instrument of torture made of **three stakes** (*tri-* “three” + *pālus* “stake” → English **pale**, **impale**).

The slide of meaning is grim and perfectly logical: *torture* → *painful toil* → *work*. Two English words came down that same road: **travail**,

painful and laborious effort; and **travel**, because journeying was once such an ordeal that the word for toil became the word for taking a trip. Etymologically, you are tortured every time you travel.

Why it's said this way

Spanish *trabajar* (“to work”) comes from the very same *tripaliāre* — a perfect cross-language twin, torture and all. The middle of the word went one way in each language: the *-al-* stayed in French (*travail*, *travailler*) and softened to *-aj-* in Spanish (*trabajo*, *trabajar*).

Grammar Lens

Nothing new — and that is the point. One template, every *-er* verb:

Person	<i>travailler</i>	Sounds like
<i>je</i>	<i>je travaille</i>	<i>tra-VYE</i>
<i>tu</i>	<i>tu travailles</i>	<i>tra-VYE</i>
<i>il / elle</i>	<i>il travaille</i>	<i>tra-VYE</i>
<i>nous</i>	<i>nous travaillons</i>	<i>tra-va-YON</i>
<i>vous</i>	<i>vous travaillez</i>	<i>tra-va-YAY</i>
<i>ils / elles</i>	<i>ils travaillent</i>	<i>tra-VYE</i>

Je travaille à Paris. — “I work in Paris.”

5.4 *Je parle français* — your first real sentence

Je (I, §2.1) + *parle* (speak, from *parler*, §5.1) + *français* (French) = **Je parle français**. A complete, grammatical French sentence — and the first one you assembled yourself rather than learned whole.

Sounds you'll need

français = *frahñ-SEH*. The cedilla under the *ç* forces a soft *s* sound where a plain *c* would have been hard; the opening *fran-* is nasal, and the final *-ais* is a plain *eh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

français (“French” — both the language and a French person) ← *Fran-cia*, “land of the **Franks**,” the Germanic people who settled Roman Gaul and gave France its name. And here is the twist: the Franks’ own name meant “**free**.” That is why English **frank** and **frankly** mean open and unguarded, and why the old French coin was called a *franc*.

Grammar Lens

Two rules hiding in four words. First, you keep the *je*. Spanish drops its pronoun — *hablo español* says “I speak Spanish” with no word for “I,” because the ending *-o* carries the person. French cannot do that: *parle*, *parles* and *parlent* all sound alike (§5.1), so the pronoun must stay. This is the single biggest structural difference between French and its Iberian cousins.

Second, **no article on the language** here: *je parle français*, not *je parle le français*.

Swap the pieces and the pattern generates new sentences: *J’habite à Paris*. (“I live in Paris.”) and *Tu parles français?* (“Do you speak French?” — no extra words needed, just raise the tone at the end).

5.5 Making sentences with -er verbs

No new words. For the first time you are not reciting phrases — you are *building* them from a pattern. Run each verb through *je / tu / il* and listen: nothing changes.

Verb	<i>je</i>	<i>tu</i>	<i>il</i>
<i>parler</i>	<i>je parle</i>	<i>tu parles</i>	<i>il parle</i>
<i>habiter</i>	<i>j’habite</i>	<i>tu habites</i>	<i>il habite</i>
<i>travailler</i>	<i>je travaille</i>	<i>tu travailles</i>	<i>il travaille</i>

Every singular form — and the *ils* form too — *sounds* the same, because *-e*, *-es* and *-ent* are silent. That is exactly why *je*, *tu* and *il* stay put: they carry the person your ear cannot hear.

Now say something real:

— *Tu parles français?* — *Oui, je parle un peu.*

— Où habites-tu? — J'habite à Lyon. Et je travaille à Paris.
 — Merci! — De rien.

(*oui* = “yes”; *un peu* = “a little”; *où* = “where”; and *merci* / *de rien* come straight back from Chapter 3.)

French	English
<i>Je parle français.</i>	I speak French.
<i>Tu parles français?</i>	Do you speak French?
<i>Oui, je parle un peu.</i>	Yes, I speak a little.
<i>J'habite à Paris.</i>	I live in Paris.
<i>Je travaille à Lyon.</i>	I work in Lyon.

What this chapter built: the **regular -er present tense** — drop *-er*, add *-e* / *-es* / *-e* / *-ons* / *-ez* / *-ent*, where the singular endings and the *ils* ending are silent, which is why the subject pronoun is mandatory. Three verbs to drill it: *parler* (from *parabolāre* — parable, parole), *habiter* (from *habitāre* — habitat, inhabit), *travailler* (from *tripalium* — travail, travel; twin of Spanish *trabajar*). And *Je parle français*, your first self-assembled sentence, with *français* from *Francia*, the land of the Franks, whose name meant “free.” French now moves in real sentences.

Chapter 6

Numbers One to Ten

Numbers are the most-reused words in any language, and French — like its sibling Spanish — inherited them almost unchanged from Latin. So you already half-know them from English, and a *Spanish twin* stands beside each one. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C06-*.md.*

6.1 *un, deux, trois, quatre, cinq* — counting to five

Sounds you'll need

un is a nasal vowel, œ said through the nose — close to “uh” hummed nasally; no *n* is actually pronounced.

deux = *deuh*, with the rounded *eu*; the *x* is silent.

French	← Latin	Spanish twin	English cousins
<i>un</i> (1)	<i>ūnus</i>	<i>uno</i>	unit, union, unique, universe
<i>deux</i> (2)	<i>duo</i>	<i>dos</i>	duo, dual, duet, double
<i>trois</i> (3)	<i>trēs</i>	<i>tres</i>	trio, triple, trident, triangle
<i>quatre</i> (4)	<i>quattuor</i>	<i>cuatro</i>	quart, quarter, quatrain, quadrant
<i>cinq</i> (5)	<i>quīnque</i>	<i>cinco</i>	quintet, quintessence

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

un also lives on in English *a/an* and *one*; French *cinq* was borrowed straight into English as **cinque**, the 5 on dice.

Latin *ūnus, duo, trēs* barely changed on the way into French and Spanish

alike — *trois* and *tres* are the same Roman *trēs*, just worn two different ways.

Grammar Lens

un → *un* / *une* (**one = a/an**). *un* doubles as the article “a/an,” and it takes gender: *un* (masculine) / *une* (feminine) — *un café* “a/one coffee,” *une bière* “a/one beer.” French makes no difference between “one” and “a,” exactly like Spanish *un/una*. The others (*deux, trois* ...) don’t change.

6.2 *six, sept, huit, neuf, dix* — and the calendar’s secret

The rest of the way to ten. These four hide the same fact the English and Spanish numbers do: *septembre–décembre* are just Latin for 7, 8, 9, 10. And *huit* shows how violently French can wear a Latin word down.

Sounds you’ll need

six and *dix* end in an *-s* sound when counting (*sees, dees*) but go silent before a consonant (*six livres = see livres*) — a liaison quirk.

neuf = *nuhf*; its *f* turns to a *v* sound before a vowel (*neuf ans = neu-v-ans*).

French	← Latin	Spanish twin	English cousins
<i>six</i> (6)	<i>sex</i>	<i>seis</i>	sextet, sextant, semester
<i>sept</i> (7)	<i>septem</i>	<i>siete</i>	septembre (the 7th month!), septet
<i>huit</i> (8)	<i>octō</i>	<i>ocho</i>	octobre (8th), octave, octopus
<i>neuf</i> (9)	<i>novem</i>	<i>nueve</i>	novembre (9th), novena
<i>dix</i> (10)	<i>decem</i>	<i>diez</i>	décembre (10th), decimal, dime

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Look at **huit**: Latin *octō* lost its *c*, softened, and grew an *h*- prop — *octō* → *oit* → *huit*. The number is unrecognizable, but *octobre* keeps the old *oct*- intact, so the 8 is still visible in the *month*.

And *dix* gave English **dime** (a tenth of a dollar), through Old French *disme* ← *decima* “a tenth.”

Grammar Lens

Why the months are “off by two.” *Septembre* means “7th,” yet it is the 9th month. Why? The old Roman year began in March, so *September* really was the seventh. Julius and Augustus later inserted *juillet* and *août* (named for themselves), shoving the counting months out of place — but the Latin numbers stuck. Every *décembre*, you are saying Roman “ten.” (Identical to the Spanish story — *diciembre* ← *decem* too.)

Chapter 7

The Days of the Week

The seven-day week is one of humanity’s oldest inheritances, and its day-names are a map of the sky: the Romans named each day for a planet-god. French kept that map almost intact — and then religion overwrote the last two. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C07-*.md.*

7.1 *lundi* to *vendredi* — the planets of the week

Once you see the trick, five days decode at once.

Sounds you’ll need

lundi = *luh(n)-DEE*, with the nasal *un* you met in *un* (one).

The shared ending *-di* is always *DEE*.

Every French weekday ends in *-di*, which is Latin *diēs*, “day.” The first part is a planet-god. Read each one as “[god]’s day”:

French	← Latin	planet-god	English echo
<i>lundi</i>	<i>lūnae diēs</i>	the Moon (<i>lune</i>)	<i>Monday</i> = Moon-day
<i>mardi</i>	<i>Martis diēs</i>	Mars	<i>Tuesday</i> (Tiw, the war-god = Mars)
<i>mercredi</i>	<i>Mercuriī diēs</i>	Mercury	<i>Wednesday</i> (Woden = Mercury)
<i>jeudi</i>	<i>Jovis diēs</i>	Jupiter (<i>Jove</i>)	<i>Thursday</i> (Thor = Jupiter)
<i>vendredi</i>	<i>Veneris diēs</i>	Venus	<i>Friday</i> (Frigg/Freya = Venus)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Here’s the beautiful part: **mardi** and **Tuesday** are the same day — both “the day of the war-god” — but Latin used *Mars* while the Germanic peoples swapped in *their* war-god, *Tiw*.

The Romans mapped their gods onto the planets; the Germanic tribes then mapped *their* gods onto the Roman ones (*interpretatio germanica*). So French *jeudi* (Jupiter) and English **Thursday** (Thor) are the king-god’s day in two pantheons.

7.2 *samedi* and *dimanche* — the week’s religious edge

Five days named for planets — and then two that aren’t. The weekend is where religion overwrote astronomy: Saturn’s day and the Sun’s day were renamed by Judaism and Christianity, and French shows both layers.

French	← Latin	meaning
<i>samedi</i>	<i>sambatī diēs</i> ← <i>Sabbatum</i>	“ Sabbath day”
<i>dimanche</i>	<i>diēs Dominica</i>	“the Lord’s day”

samedi still has the *-di* (*diēs*), but the god is gone — replaced by the Hebrew *shabbat*, “rest.” In *dimanche* the *-di* jumped to the *front* (*di-manche*); *Dominica* comes from *Dominus*, “lord, master.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Two different rewrites.

samedi would have been “Saturn’s day” (as English **Saturday** still is — the one weekday English kept a Roman god for!). But Latin Christians took the Jewish **Sabbath** (*Sabbatum* ← Hebrew *shabbāt*, “to rest”) and it became *samedi*. So English *Saturday* and French *samedi* are the same day under two names — the planet versus the Sabbath.

dimanche dropped Sun-worship entirely: where English keeps **Sunday**, French made it *diēs Dominica*, “the Lord’s day” (*Dominus* → English **dominion, dominate, dame**). Notice the *di-* is now in front — a fossil of *diēs* that moved.

7.2. SAMEDI AND DIMANCHE — *THE WEEK'S RELIGIOUS EDGE*39

French	English
<i>lundi</i>	Monday
<i>mardi</i>	Tuesday
<i>mercredi</i>	Wednesday
<i>jeudi</i>	Thursday
<i>vendredi</i>	Friday
<i>samedi</i>	Saturday
<i>dimanche</i>	Sunday

Chapter 8

Telling the Time

With your numbers in hand, you can tell the time. It takes one key word, *heure* (“hour”), plus two hours that refuse a number and take a name instead: *midi* and *minuit*. Practice lessons: *lessons/FR-C08-*.md*.

8.1 *heure* — the hour, and telling the time

Sounds you’ll need

The *h* of *heure* is silent (as in English *hour*): say *eur*.

Because it starts with a vowel-sound, the number links onto it: *deux heures* = *deu-z-eur*, *trois heures* = *troi-z-eur*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

heure ← Latin *hōra* ← Greek *hōrā*. The Greek word meant “a period, a season, the right time” (the goddesses of the seasons were the *Horae*); Latin narrowed it to “hour,” and French wore *hōra* down to *heure*.

English took the same Latin *hōra* and made **hour** — so *heure* and *hour* are the same word, spelt apart. (The silent *h* in both is a fossil of the Latin spelling.)

Grammar Lens

il est ... heure(s). To tell the clock time, French says *il est* (“it is”) + the number + *heure(s)*. Literally “it is two *hours*” — French counts the hours, where English says “o’clock” (itself a worn-down “of the clock”). Add *et quart* (“and a quarter”), *et demie* (“and a half”), *moins le quart* (“quarter to”) later; the core is *il est ... heures*.

French	English	note
<i>Il est une heure.</i>	It is one o'clock.	<i>une heure</i> — singular
<i>Il est deux heures.</i>	It is two o'clock.	<i>deux heures</i> — plural
<i>Il est dix heures.</i>	It is ten o'clock.	

8.2 *midi* and *minuit* — noon and midnight

Two hours don't get a number — they get a name. *midi* (noon) and *minuit* (midnight) are the pivots of the day, and both are literally “the middle” of the day and of the night.

French	← Latin	literally
<i>midi</i>	<i>medius diēs</i>	“the mid-day ”
<i>minuit</i>	<i>media nox</i>	“the mid-night ”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

midi = *medius diēs*, “mid-day.” You can still see both halves: *mi-* is “middle” (from *medius*, cousin of English **medium**, **mid**, **middle**), and *-di* is the *diēs* “day” you met in *lundi* and *mardi*. So *midi* is “the day's middle.”

minuit = *media nox*, “mid-night.” Here *mi-* is again “middle,” and *-nuit* is *nox/noct-*, “night” (cousin of English **night**, and the *noct-* of **nocturnal**). So *minuit* is “the night's middle” — exactly like English **mid-night**.

To use them, drop the *heures* — they *are* the hour: *Il est midi*. “It is noon.” *Il est minuit*. “It is midnight.”

Why it's said this way

English **noon** comes from Latin *nōna hōra*, “the *ninth* hour” — once mid-afternoon, it drifted earlier until it landed on midday. French kept the tidier “mid-day.”

Chapter 9

Months and Seasons

The French calendar is a procession of Roman gods and emperors, carried almost unchanged out of Latin — and the four seasons are four small Latin poems about heat, sleep, and first things. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C09-*.md.*

9.1 *les mois* — the calendar’s gods and Caesars

The twelve French months are a **procession of Roman gods and emperors**, almost unchanged from Latin. Two of them pay off twice: *mars* is the war-god who also names Tuesday, and *septembre–décembre* are still the Latin numbers seven to ten.

French	← Latin	who / what
<i>janvier</i>	<i>Januarius</i>	Janus , two-faced god of doors and beginnings
<i>février</i>	<i>Februarius</i>	<i>Februa</i> , the Roman purification festival
<i>mars</i>	<i>Martius</i>	Mars , the war-god
<i>avril</i>	<i>Aprilis</i>	perhaps <i>aperire</i> , “to open ” (buds opening)
<i>mai</i>	<i>Maius</i>	Maia , goddess of growth
<i>juin</i>	<i>Junius</i>	Juno , queen of the gods
<i>juillet</i>	<i>Julius</i>	Julius Caesar (he inserted this month)
<i>août</i>	<i>Augustus</i>	the emperor Augustus (he inserted this one)
<i>septembre</i>	<i>september</i>	“ 7th ” (<i>septem</i>)
<i>octobre</i>	<i>october</i>	“ 8th ” (<i>octo</i>)
<i>novembre</i>	<i>november</i>	“ 9th ” (<i>novem</i>)
<i>décembre</i>	<i>december</i>	“ 10th ” (<i>decem</i>)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mars = Mars = mardi. The month and the weekday honour the *same* war-god — *Martius* (his month) and *Martis diēs* (his day). Spot one, and you know the other.

The 7–10 months. *Septembre* through *décembre* still carry *septem*, *octo*, *novem*, *decem* — because the old Roman year began in **March**, so September really *was* the seventh month. Then **Julius** and **Augustus** shoved two months in (*juillet*, *août*), the counting slid out of place — but the names stuck.

Why it's said this way

Two of the twelve are named for *people* rather than gods: *juillet* for Julius Caesar and *août* for the emperor Augustus. Each man put his own month into the calendar, and two thousand years later France still says their names every summer.

9.2 *les saisons* — the four seasons

Four words for the turning year: **le printemps**, **l'été**, **l'automne**, **l'hiver**. Each traces to Latin, and the first one is a small poem — *printemps* means, almost literally, “the first time.”

French	← Latin	literally
<i>le printemps</i> (spring)	<i>prīnum tempus</i>	“the first time / prime season ”
<i>l'été</i> (summer)	<i>aestās / aestātem</i>	“heat, the hot season”
<i>l'automne</i> (autumn)	<i>autumnus</i>	“autumn” — the word English borrowed
<i>l'hiver</i> (winter)	<i>hibernum (tempus)</i>	“the wintry season”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

printemps = *prime* + *temps* (“time, weather”): the year’s *first* season, its “prime time.” Older French used *primevère* — the same *prima vera* (“first spring”) that Italian keeps as *primavera*.

été ← *aestās*, “heat” — summer as the hot season; English **estival** (also spelled **aestival**) means “of summer.”

automne ← *autumnus*: the *m* stayed in the spelling, the *n* went silent.

hiver ← *hibernum*, “wintry” — and English **hibernate** is literally “to spend the winter.” Same root: one a season, one a bear’s sleep.

Grammar Lens

Saying “in” a season. Spring is the odd one out: *au printemps*, but *en été* / *en automne* / *en hiver*. Only spring takes *au*.

Chapter 10

Family

Four words — father, mother, brother, sister — and every one of them is among the oldest words we can reconstruct, older than Latin, older than Rome. Each is also a key to a whole shelf of English vocabulary. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C10-*.md.*

10.1 *le père, la mère* — the oldest words in the family

The words for “father” and “mother” are among the **oldest words we can reconstruct**. French kept them almost bare: **père** and **mère**. And they are secretly the *same words* as English **father** and **mother**.

French	English
<i>le père</i>	the father
<i>la mère</i>	the mother

Note the articles: *le* père is masculine, *la* mère is feminine — the gender you have been tracking since the first chapter.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

le père (“father”) ← Latin *pater* ← Proto-Indo-European **ph₂tér*.

la mère (“mother”) ← Latin *māter* ← Proto-Indo-European **méh₂tēr*.

The Latin root also gives English its “of a parent” adjectives: **paternal**, **paternity**, **patron**; and **maternal**, **maternity**, **matron**, and even **matter** (*māter* → *materia*, “the stuff a tree-mother makes”).

Grammar Lens

One sound-law, two languages. French took *pater* and *māter* straight from Latin. English took the *same* Proto-Indo-European words down a different road, through **Grimm’s law**, which turned $p \rightarrow f$ and $t \rightarrow th$:

Proto-Indo-European	Latin / French	English
<i>*ph₂tér</i>	<i>pater</i> → <i>père</i>	father
<i>*méh₂tēr</i>	<i>māter</i> → <i>mère</i>	mother

So *père* and *father* are not lookalikes borrowed late — they are the **same inherited word**, one keeping the *p*, the other shifting it to *f*.

10.2 *le frère, la sœur* — brother and sister

With parents in hand, the next pair: **frère** (“brother”) and **sœur** (“sister”). Both come straight from Latin, and both hand English a whole family of words.

French	English
<i>le frère</i>	the brother
<i>la sœur</i>	the sister

Sounds you’ll need

sœur is spelled with *œ* — an *o* and an *e* fused into a single letter. It spells the vowel that *soror* wore down to: *soror* → *seror* → *sœur*. Spell it aloud as “s-œ-u-r,” remembering that the *œ* counts as *one* letter.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

le frère (“brother”) ← Latin *frāter* ← Proto-Indo-European **b^hréh₂tēr* — the same root that, through Grimm’s law ($b^h \rightarrow b$), gave English **brother**. It also gives **fraternal**, **fraternity**, **fraternize**, and — softened in old French — **friar**, a “brother” in a religious order.

la sœur (“sister”) ← Latin *soror*, behind English **sorority** and **sororal**; and a sister in a convent is still called a *sœur*. English **sister** comes from the *same* Proto-Indo-European root **swésōr*, by the Germanic road —

Latin *soror* and English *sister* are cousins.

The four family words now form a set — *père, mère, frère, sœur* — and each one is a key to a Latin-through-English word: **p**aternal, **m**aternal, **f**raternal, **s**orority.

Chapter 11

Bread, Water, Wine

Food at last — and three words that sit at the centre of the French table. One of them hides the loveliest word-story in English; another is the most worn-down word French ever took from Latin. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C11-*.md.*

11.1 *le pain* — bread, and the people you share it with

le pain (“bread”) is the heart of the French table — and its Latin root hides one of the loveliest word-stories in English: your **companion** is, literally, someone you **share bread** with.

Sounds you’ll need

le pain carries the nasal vowel spelled *-ain*: the air goes through the nose, and the final *-n* is not pronounced as a separate consonant. It is masculine: *le pain*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

le pain (“bread”) ← Latin *pānis*. The root *pān-* feeds a surprising table of English words:

companion / **company** ← *com-* (“with”) + *pānis* — “one you break bread with.” A *company* was first a group sharing meals.

pantry — the room where the bread (and the rest of the food) is kept.

pannier — a bread-basket, now the bag slung over a bicycle or a donkey.

Why it's said this way

So *le pain* is the same root as **companion**: French kept the bread, English kept the friendship built on it. Two useful everyday forms: *un pain* (“a loaf”) and *du pain* (“some bread”).

11.2 *l'eau, le vin* — water and wine

The two drinks of the French table. One of them, **eau**, is the single most **worn-down** word French took from Latin: it began as *aqua* and ended as a bare “oh.”

French	English
<i>l'eau</i>	the water
<i>le vin</i>	the wine

Sounds you'll need

l'eau is pronounced simply “oh” — three letters, *e-a-u*, spelling one vowel sound. It takes *l'* rather than *le* or *la* because it begins with a vowel. *le vin* has the nasal vowel of *-in*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

l'eau (“water”) ← Latin *aqua*. Watch the erosion: *aqua* → *ewe* → *eaue* → *eau*, until only the vowel “oh” remains. French quite literally *drank the consonants out of aqua*.

The original *aqua* is still loud in English, because English borrowed the Latin word *whole*: **aquatic**, **aquarium**, **aqueduct**, **aqualung** — and Italian *acqua* barely changed at all. So *l'eau* and *aquarium* are the far ends of the same word.

le vin (“wine”) ← Latin *vīnum*. Unlike *eau*, this one held its shape, and English shares it: **wine** itself is *vīnum* borrowed into old Germanic, plus **vine**, **vinegar** (*vin* + *aigre*, “sour wine”), **vintage**, **vineyard**, **vinyl**. Wine mattered enough to keep its name across every border.

Chapter 12

Numbers Eleven to Twenty

The French teens are not built the way you would guess. Six of them came out of Latin already welded together; then, at exactly seventeen, the language changes its mind in front of you. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C12-*.md.*

12.1 *onze* → *seize* — six numbers welded together

French did not say “ten-one, ten-two.” It inherited six numbers already **fused** in Latin, and they came through almost unrecognisable.

	French	← Latin	literally
11	<i>onze</i>	<i>ūndecim</i>	“one-ten”
12	<i>douze</i>	<i>duodecim</i>	“two-ten”
13	<i>treize</i>	<i>trēdecim</i>	“three-ten”
14	<i>quatorze</i>	<i>quattuordecim</i>	“four-ten”
15	<i>quinze</i>	<i>quīndecim</i>	“five-ten”
16	<i>seize</i>	<i>sēdecim</i>	“six-ten”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Look at the ending they all share: **-ze**. That is Latin *decem* (“ten”), worn down to almost nothing — the *same* ten that hides in *dix* (10) and in *décembre*, the old tenth month. One root, three disguises.

Grammar Lens

The digit is still in there. The front of each word is the small number it is built on: *un* → *on-*, *deux* → *dou-*, *trois* → *trei-*, *quatre* → *quator-*, *cinq* → *quin-*, *six* → *sei-*. Say them slowly and the small number

surfaces. Note the order: the *digit* comes first and the *ten* second — *trēdecim* is “three-ten,” not “ten-three.”

12.2 *dix-sept* → *vingt* — where French changes its mind

Here is something you can *watch happen*. Up to *seize* (16), French used the old welded-together Latin numbers. Then, at **17**, it simply gives up — and starts saying the numbers plainly, the way a child would.

	French	how it is built
16	<i>seize</i>	one fused word (← <i>sēdecim</i>)
17	<i>dix-sept</i>	“ten-seven” — two words, plainly
18	<i>dix-huit</i>	“ten-eight”
19	<i>dix-neuf</i>	“ten-nine”
20	<i>vingt</i>	← <i>vīgintī</i>

Grammar Lens

Two things change at the seam. In *seize*, the digit came *first* (“six-ten”). In *dix-sept*, the *ten* comes first (“ten-seven”). So at exactly 17 French switched both its **strategy** (fused → transparent) and its **direction** (digit-first → ten-first) — a visible seam in the counting system. Latin itself wobbled here: it had *septendecim* for 17, but for 18 and 19 it counted *down* from twenty — *duodēvīgintī*, “two-from-twenty.” The daughter languages all abandoned that subtraction trick.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

vingt (20) ← Latin *vīgintī*, the root behind English **vigesimal** (“counting by twenties”) — and the reason French later builds *quatre-vingts* (80 = “four twenties”).

Chapter 13

Colours

Four basic colours — *noir*, *blanc*, *rouge*, *bleu* — and a surprise inside them: half of them are not Latin at all. Two walked down from Rome; two walked in from the Germanic north, against the usual direction of traffic. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C13-*.md.*

13.1 *noir*, *blanc* — one inherited, one borrowed

Two colours, two completely different life stories. One walked straight down from Latin. The other was borrowed from the Germanic neighbours — and that direction, Germanic *into* Romance, is the opposite of what usually happens.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

noir (“black”) ← Latin *niger*. No surprises: *niger* → *negro* / *nero* in the sister languages, and into English in **denigrate** (“to blacken someone’s name”).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

blanc (“white”) is the imported one. You’d expect Latin *albus* (“white”). It’s not there. French says *blanc*, from Frankish **blank* — a Germanic word meaning “**shining, gleaming**.” The Franks who gave France its name gave it its word for white too.

Why did *albus* lose? Probably because *blank* was *vivid*: not just “white” but “bright, flashing.” Colour words often get replaced by the more dramatic option.

Albus didn’t die — it stopped being a colour:

Word	Meaning	The white inside
<i>aube</i>	dawn	the sky going <i>white</i>
<i>aubépine</i>	hawthorn	the “white thorn”
album (Eng.)	album	a <i>blank white</i> tablet
albino (Eng.)	albino	white-skinned

So Latin’s white is still all around you — just never where you’d look for it.

Grammar Lens

Say them. *noir, blanc*. Then put them to work on a noun you already have: *le vin blanc, le vin rouge*. And hold the pairing in your head — *noir* from Latin, *blanc* from the Franks. Say *l’aube* and hear the old Latin white still sitting inside it.

13.2 *rouge, bleu* — an ancient word and a borrowed one

The last section gave one inherited colour and one borrowed. This one repeats the pattern — and shows that French’s borrowing from Germanic wasn’t a one-off.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

rouge (“red”) ← Latin *rubeus* (“reddish”). But *rubeus* itself descends from a root so old it predates Latin: Proto-Indo-European **h₁rewdʰ-*. Its children are everywhere.

Language	Word
Latin	<i>ruber, rubeus</i> → <i>rouge, ruby, rubric</i>
English	red, rust, ruddy
German	<i>rot</i>

So *rouge* and **red** are not lookalikes — they are *actual cousins*, separated for maybe five thousand years. Red is one of humanity’s oldest named colours.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bleu (“blue”) ← Frankish **blāo*. Another Germanic word, borrowed exactly like *blanc*. And then something neat happened: English took *bleu* from French — so English **blue** is a Germanic word that went to France, changed clothes, and came back. German kept the original at home: *blau*.

Why it’s said this way

French also has *azur* (from the same source as Spanish *azul*, ultimately Arabic *lāzaward*, “lapis lazuli”) — the poetic blue of the sky, and the *Côte d’Azur*.

The pattern of the chapter, laid out:

Colour	Source
<i>noir</i>	Latin <i>niger</i>
<i>blanc</i>	Germanic <i>*blank</i>
<i>rouge</i>	Latin <i>rubeus</i> (ancient PIE root)
<i>bleu</i>	Germanic <i>*blāo</i>

Half of French’s basic colour vocabulary walked in from the north.

Why it’s said this way

Say them in the order of the flag: *bleu*, *blanc*, *rouge*. All three are now yours — and two of the three are loanwords. The French tricolour is, quietly, two-thirds Germanic.

Grammar Lens

Practice. Say *rouge*, *bleu*. Say *le vin rouge* — the wine you already know, now with its colour. Say the cousins out loud in a row: *rouge* · **red** · *rot*. Next chapter: the verb *avoir*, and something French does with it that English would never do.

Chapter 14

To Have, and How Old You Are

The verb French leans on hardest, and the first thing it lets you say that English cannot say the same way: your age. French does not *be* twenty — it *has* twenty years. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C14-*.md.*

14.1 *avoir* — “to have”

The verb French leans on hardest. It’s irregular, it’s everywhere, and — as you’ll see — you have already met its root without knowing it.

Singular	Plural
<i>j’ai</i> (I have)	<i>nous avons</i> (we have)
<i>tu as</i> (you have)	<i>vous avez</i> (you have)
<i>il/elle a</i> (he/she has)	<i>ils/elles ont</i> (they have)

Sounds you’ll need

Say the singular column: *ai*, *as*, *a* — three forms, and they all sound the *same*. The written endings differ; your ear can’t tell them apart. Only the pronoun tells you who.

Note *j’ai*, not *je ai*: before a vowel, *je* loses its *e*. That is the elision French does everywhere — the same move that turns *le eau* into *l’eau*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

avoir (“to have”) ← Latin *habēre*. And the verb *habiter* (“to live somewhere”) ← *habitāre* — which is just *habēre* run through a “keep doing it” pattern: *to keep having a place*. Same root, both verbs.

The family in English is large, because English borrowed it whole:

English word	Inside it
habit	what you <i>have</i> regularly
inhabit	to <i>have</i> a place — = <i>habiter</i>
exhibit	to <i>hold</i> out
prohibit	to <i>hold</i> back

Grammar Lens

How far it wore down. Latin *habeō* (“I have”) → French *j’ai*. Four syllables of Latin reduced to a *single vowel sound*. French does this more than any of its sisters — compare Italian *ho*, Spanish *he*, and the Latin *aqua* that French ground down to *eau*.

Sounds you’ll need

Practice. Say the six: *j’ai, tu as, il a, nous avons, vous avez, ils ont*. Then say the three that sound alike — *ai · as · a*. Then a whole sentence: *J’ai un frère* (“I have a brother”). Then the root pair: *avoir · habiter*.

14.2 *j’ai vingt ans* — having your years

Ask a French speaker their age and the answer uses *avoir*. Not “I am twenty” — “**I have twenty years.**” English can’t do this; Spanish and Italian do exactly the same thing.

— *Quel âge as-tu ?* — “What age do you have?”
 — *J’ai vingt ans.* — “I have twenty years.”

Grammar Lens

Two things to notice. First, the verb is **avoir**, never *être* — *je suis vingt ans* is simply wrong. Second, *ans* is compulsory: English drops it (“I’m twenty”); French cannot.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

an (“year”) ← Latin *annus*, which gives English **annual**, **anniversary**, **annals**, and *per annum*. You have already met its descendants: the month names come from the same calendar.

Sounds you'll need

Careful with the sound: *an* is **nasal**, and in *vingt ans* the silent *t* of *vingt* wakes up and links — *vin-t-an*. That is **liaison**, French's habit of reviving a dead consonant when a vowel follows.

Who else does it this way:

Language	"I am 20"	Verb
French	<i>j'ai vingt ans</i>	have
Spanish	<i>tengo veinte años</i>	have
Italian	<i>ho venti anni</i>	have
Portuguese	<i>tenho vinte anos</i>	have
German	<i>ich bin zwanzig Jahre alt</i>	be
English	<i>I am twenty</i>	be

A clean split: **Romance has its years; Germanic is its years.** Age as something you *carry* versus age as something you *are*.

Why it's said this way

Practice. Say *Quel âge as-tu ?* Then *J'ai vingt ans*, with the liaison — *vin-t-an*. Then your own age, using the numbers you have. Then the split itself: French *a* its years; English *is* its years. Next chapter: what French builds *out of avoir* — a whole past tense.

Chapter 15

The Compound Past

French's everyday past tense is built out of *avoir* — and it began life not as a tense at all, but as a sentence about *possessing* something. Then we meet the older past it pushed out of the language. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C15-*.md.*

15.1 *j'ai parlé* — the past built from “have”

French's everyday past tense. You already have both halves of it: the verb *avoir*, and the *-er* verbs.

avoir (conjugated) + past participle

Infinitive	Ends in	Participle
<i>parler</i>	<i>-er</i>	<i>parlé</i>
<i>habiter</i>	<i>-er</i>	<i>habité</i>
<i>finir</i>	<i>-ir</i>	<i>fini</i>
<i>vendre</i>	<i>-re</i>	<i>vendu</i>

So:

French	English
<i>j'ai parlé</i>	I spoke / I have spoken
<i>tu as parlé</i>	you spoke
<i>il a parlé</i>	he spoke
<i>nous avons parlé</i>	we spoke
<i>ils ont parlé</i>	they spoke

Only *avoir* changes. The participle sits there unchanged.

Sounds you'll need

parler, *parlé* and *parlez* are all pronounced *the same*. Three spellings, one sound — the context tells you which.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Where the endings come from: *parlé* ← Latin *-ātum*; *fini* ← *-ītum*; *vendu* ← *-ūtum*. The same *-t-* that English kept in **finite**, **acute**, **statute**.

A footnote on the third one: *-ūtus* was a *rare* ending in Latin (*minūtus*, *tribūtus*). French and Italian took that small class and spread it over a whole conjugation. So *-é* and *-i* are straight inheritance; *-u* is mostly the language tidying up by analogy.

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The buried possessive. Here is why this tense exists. Latin could say *habēo litterās scriptās* — “I *have* letters *written*.”

That is not a past tense. It is *avoir* in its ordinary sense — I *possess* some letters — with *scriptās* as an **adjective** describing them, agreeing with *litterās* in gender and number.

Over centuries the phrase stopped meaning “I possess a written thing” and started meaning simply “**I wrote**.” A possessive construction hardened into a tense.

And the fossil is still visible: when the object comes *first*, the participle still agrees with it, exactly as an adjective would — *Les lettres que j'ai écrites*, “The letters that I wrote.” That *-es* is a two-thousand-year-old adjective ending doing its old job.

Sounds you'll need

Practice. Say the set: *j'ai parlé*, *tu as parlé*, *il a parlé*, *nous avons parlé*, *ils ont parlé*. Say the three homophones — *parler* · *parlé* · *parlez*. Say *J'ai travaillé* (“I worked”). Then say the old meaning out loud: “I *have* a thing *spoken*.”

15.2 *il parla* — the past you read but never say

French has a *second* past tense. You will meet it in every novel and never hear it spoken. Knowing why is worth more than knowing its endings.

	<i>Passé simple</i>	<i>Passé composé</i>
he spoke	<i>il parla</i>	<i>il a parlé</i>
they spoke	<i>ils parlèrent</i>	<i>ils ont parlé</i>
he had	<i>il eut</i>	<i>il a eu</i>

You do *not* need to produce these. You need to recognise them, because they fill the past tense of essentially all French literature.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

il parla ← Vulgar Latin **parabolāvit* — the plain Latin perfect, handed straight down. Which means the *passé simple* is the *same tense* as Spanish *habló* and Portuguese *falou*.

Language	“he spoke”	Status
French	<i>il parla</i>	books only
Spanish	<i>habló</i>	everyday speech
Portuguese	<i>falou</i>	everyday speech
Italian	<i>parlò</i>	regional — see below

Same Latin ancestor, four different fates.

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The retreat, three times over. French is not alone.

Language	Simple past	What replaced it in speech
French	<i>passé simple</i>	<i>passé composé</i> (<i>j’ai parlé</i>)
German	<i>Präteritum</i>	<i>Perfekt</i> (<i>ich habe gesagt</i>)
Italian	<i>passato remoto</i>	<i>passato prossimo</i> (<i>ho parlato</i>)

Three languages — two Romance, one Germanic — each built a compound past out of “have,” and each let that compound push the inherited simple past out of everyday conversation and into writing.

Why it's said this way

Not three separate inventions, though. They are **neighbours**: France, southern Germany and northern Italy form a connected block, and the change spread through it by *contact* over the same few centuries. Linguists call this an *areal* change — one that travels across language boundaries because the speakers do.

And Spanish and Portuguese, out at the western edge of that block, largely *didn't* get it. They kept their simple past where it was. (Though Spain's Spanish has since started drifting the same way, with *he hablado* taking ground from *habló* — the change reaching the edge late.)

Sounds you'll need

Practice. Say the pair — *il parla ... il a parlé*. Say the sisters — *il parla · habló · falou · parlò*. Remind yourself where you'd meet it: in a *novel*, not a conversation. And say the three retreats — *passé simple · Präteritum · passato remoto*. Next chapter: the other auxiliary, and the verbs that refuse *avoir*.

Chapter 16

To Be, and the Past That Takes It

The partner of *avoir*, and the most irregular verb in the language — for a reason worth knowing. Then the small group of verbs that refuse *avoir* in the past and take *être* instead. *Practice lessons: lessons/FR-C16-*.md.*

16.1 *être* — “to be”

The other verb everything is built on. *Avoir* was one half; this is its partner — and it is the most irregular verb in French.

Singular	Plural
<i>je suis</i> (I am)	<i>nous sommes</i> (we are)
<i>tu es</i> (you are)	<i>vous êtes</i> (you are)
<i>il/elle est</i> (he/she is)	<i>ils/elles sont</i> (they are)

There is no pattern to find. Don’t look for one — these are among the oldest word-shapes in Europe, worn smooth by three thousand years of daily use.

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Three stems in a trench coat. Line the forms up against Latin and the seams show.

French	← Latin
<i>je suis</i>	<i>sum</i> — “I am”
<i>tu es</i>	<i>es</i>
<i>il est</i>	<i>est</i>
<i>nous sommes</i>	<i>sumus</i>
<i>ils sont</i>	<i>sunt</i>
<i>être</i>	* <i>essere</i> , Vulgar Latin’s remodelling of <i>esse</i>

All of those come from *esse*, “to be” — the infinitive included. Now the pieces that come from somewhere else entirely:

French	← Latin
<i>je fus</i> , <i>il fut</i> (<i>passé simple</i>)	<i>fuī</i> — an ancient perfect stem
<i>été</i> (past participle)	<i>stāre</i> — “to stand”
<i>étant</i> (present participle)	<i>stāre</i> again (<i>stantem</i>)
<i>j’étais</i> , <i>il était</i> (imperfect)	<i>stāre</i> again (<i>stābam</i>)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Fus and *été* are not related to *suis* at all. The first is an ancient perfect stem (from Proto-Indo-European **b^huH-*, “grow, become” — the source of English **be**); the second is the Latin verb for **standing**.

And look how much of *stāre* is in there. It isn’t one stray form: *every* French *être* form beginning *ét-* comes from the standing verb — *été*, *étant*, *étais*, *était*. A whole limb of the verb.

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Three stems, then: *es-* for the present and infinitive, *fu-* for the *passé simple*, *ét-* for the participles and the imperfect. That patching is called **suppletion** — one verb’s paradigm filled in with pieces of another, exactly like English *go* / *went* (where *went* was stolen from *wend*).

Why it’s said this way

The Spanish connection. *Stāre* should look familiar. It is the verb Spanish turned into *estar*, its second “to be,” held apart from *ser*. So Spanish has *ser* ← *esse* and *estar* ← *stāre*, kept as two separate verbs; French has one verb, *être* ← *esse*, having absorbed *stāre*’s whole *ét-* limb. Spanish kept the two verbs *apart* and made you choose between them.

French kept one verb and swallowed a large piece of the other. Same two Latin sources, opposite solutions.

(*Stāre* also left French words outside *être* — *rester* ← *re-stāre*, “to stay,” and *coûter* ← *constāre*. What it did *not* do is survive as a separate “to be” the way *estar* did.)

Sounds you’ll need

Practice. Say the six: *je suis, tu es, il est, nous sommes, vous êtes, ils sont*. Say two whole sentences: *Je suis français, Je suis fatigué*. Then say the seam — *suis* ← *sum* ... *fus* ← *fuī* ... *ét-* ← *stāre*. And the English parallel: *go / went*.

16.2 *je suis allé* — the past built from “be”

The last chapter built the past with *avoir*: *j’ai parlé*. But a small, important group of verbs refuses *avoir* and takes *être* instead — and when they do, something visible happens to the participle.

Verbs of motion and change of state take être.

Aller (“to go”) is the headline case:

French	English
<i>je suis allé</i>	I went
<i>tu es allé</i>	you went
<i>il est allé</i>	he went
<i>nous sommes allés</i>	we went
<i>ils sont allés</i>	they went

Others in the family: *venir* (come), *partir* (leave), *arriver* (arrive), *entrer*, *sortir*, *monter*, *descendre*, *naître* (be born), *mourir* (die), *rester* (stay), *tomber* (fall). Read that list as a shape rather than a list: **going, coming, being born, dying** — arriving and leaving, in space or in life.

Plus one whole extra family: all pronominal verbs take *être* — *je me suis levé, elle s’est lavée*. Careful, though: they take *être* but they do *not* follow *être*’s agreement rule. See the warning at the end of this section.

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Two warnings, so the rule doesn't mislead you.

Not every motion verb qualifies. *Marcher, courir, nager, danser, voyager* all take *avoir* (*j'ai couru*). The *être* verbs are about arriving, leaving, and changing state — not about moving your legs.

Some switch when they take an object. *Monter, descendre, sortir, rentrer, passer* take *être* alone (*je suis monté*, “I went up”) but *avoir* with a direct object (*j'ai monté les valises*, “I took the suitcases up”).

The participle agrees with the subject. This is the part you can see and hear:

French	English
<i>Il est allé.</i>	He went.
<i>Elle est allée.</i>	She went.
<i>Ils sont allés.</i>	They went.
<i>Elles sont allées.</i>	They (f.) went.

The participle takes the subject's gender and number — exactly like an adjective.

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Why? The same fossil as the last chapter. *Elle est allée* began as a plain description: “*she is gone*” — *gone* describing *her*, the way *elle est fatiguée* describes her. It was never an action she performed on something; it was a state she was in. So the participle agreed with her, and it still does.

Compare the two halves of the system:

Auxiliary	Participle agrees with	Because it was...
<i>avoir</i>	a preceding object (<i>les lettres que j'ai écrites</i>)	“I have letters written”
<i>être</i>	the subject (<i>elle est allée</i>)	“she is gone”

One rule underneath both: **the participle was an adjective, and it agrees with whatever it described.**

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The pronominal exception. Pronominal verbs take *être* — but their agreement follows the *avoir* rule, not the *être* one. They agree with a preceding direct object, which usually *is* the reflexive pronoun, and sometimes isn’t.

Elle s’est lavée. — She washed *herself*; *se* is the direct object, so it agrees.

Elle s’est lavé les mains. — She washed *her hands*; the object is *les mains*, and it follows, so no agreement.

Elles se sont parlé. — They spoke *to each other*; *se* is indirect, so no agreement.

Which is, satisfyingly, the same rule as the last chapter all along. The auxiliary looks like *être*; the agreement behaves like *avoir*. Don’t let the first mislead you about the second.

One group in particular escapes even that. Verbs that exist *only* in pronominal form — *se souvenir* (remember), *s’enfuir* (flee), *s’évanouir* (faint) — have no non-reflexive version for the pronoun to be an object *of*, so they simply agree with the subject: *elles se sont souvenues*.

Sounds you’ll need

Practice. Say *je suis allé, il est allé, elle est allée*. Say the contrast — *j’ai parlé ... je suis allé*. Say the shape of the list: going, coming, born, dying. And say the reason out loud: “*she is gone*” — *gone* describes *her*.

You now have two verbs holding up the whole language, *avoir* and *être*; a past tense built from each; and the single old idea — the participle as an adjective — that explains both. That is a working past. The next volume turns from what has happened to what is in front of you: describing what you see.